

GP-49-HI

Sept 1944

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49th Fighter Group
Sep 1944

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~~SECRET~~GP-49-#1
SEP 44DESIGNATION SHEET

AIR FORCE : Fifth Air Force
COMMAND : V Fighter Command
WING : 86th Fighter Wing
GROUP : 49th Fighter Group

P.R.C.

September 1944

Has security classification of material been checked? YesDECLASSIFIED
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EXHIBIT

1. [illegible]	1. [illegible]
2. [illegible]	2. [illegible]
3. [illegible]	3. [illegible]
4. [illegible]	4. [illegible]

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HEADQUARTERS 49TH FIGHTER GROUP
ARMY AIR FORCES
APO 72

27 November 1944

SECRET

Auth. CG VFC

Init.

SUBJECT: Transmittal of Unit Histories.

TO : Commanding General, Army Air Forces, Washington, 25, D.C.

1. In compliance with AR 345-105 and AAF Regulation No. 20-8, submit herewith Chapter 11 (September 1944) of the histories of this organization, which has been inspected and verified by the undersigned.

2. The material submitted for the Headquarters history was prepared by 1st Lieut. Robert J. Boniece, 0468372, Air Corps. Facts and observations included in the narrative and not otherwise credited are based on the personal knowledge and opinions of Lieut. Boniece.

3. The following materials are included:

- a. Historical Report, Headquarters, 49th Fighter Group, for September, 1944.
- b. Historical Report, 7th Fighter Squadron, for September, 1944.
- c. Historical Report, 8th Fighter Squadron, for September, 1944.
- d. Historical Report, 9th Fighter Squadron, for September, 1944.

George A. Walker
GEORGE A. WALKER,
Lt Col Air Corps
Commanding.



MEMORANDUM FOR THE RECORD
SUBJECT: [REDACTED]
DATE: 10/25/54

10/25/54
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SUBJECT: Transmittal of Unit Histories.

TO : Commanding General, Army Air Forces, Washington, D.C.

1. The material submitted for the Headquarters, Army Air Forces, Washington, D.C., is being submitted for the purpose of being included in the official history of the Army Air Forces, which has been requested and verified by the interested organization.

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3. The following materials are included:

- a. Historical Report, Headquarters, 1st Fighter Group, for September, 1944.
- b. Historical Report, 1st Fighter Squadron, for September, 1944.
- c. Historical Report, 2nd Fighter Squadron, for September, 1944.
- d. Historical Report, 3rd Fighter Squadron, for September, 1944.

10/25/54
10/25/54
10/25/54



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HISTORY OF THE 49TH FIGHTER GROUP

*

Chapter 11
(1-30 September, 1944)

49th Fighter Group
86th Fighter Wing
V Fighter Command
Fifth Air Force
United States Army



HISTORY OF THE AIR FORCE GROUP

Chapter 11
(1-30 September, 1941)

1941 Fighter Group
1941 Fighter Wing
1941 Fighter Command
1941 Air Force
United States Army



HEADQUARTERS 49TH FIGHTER GROUP
ARMY AIR FORCES
APO 72

27 November, 1944.

GROUP HISTORICAL RECORDS (SEPTEMBER 1944)

Anyone standing at a safe distance and watching the 49th Fighter Group during the month of September would witness a whirlwind of activity. A peek through the dust at the airstrip would reveal the 7th and 8th Squadron pilots bidding farewell to their faithful P-40's and undergoing a rigorous training program to acquaint themselves with the twin engined P-38. Although many pilots were reluctant to make the change because of a fond nostalgic feeling for the Kittyhawks and Warhawks they realized the advantages of the increased range and speed gained with the P-38. Let no man be foolish enough to make any slightly disparaging remark about a P-40 to these pilots, else the foolhardy one find himself pinned down by an extremely irate fighter pilot whose respect for that plane will never dwindle. As an all round rugged fighter and dive bomber the '40 will never be forgotten by the old 49ers who flew them from Darwin to Biak, fighting, bombing and strafing.

This intensive training program was not without accidents. The 8th Squadron had its troubles and tragedies. On September 1st, 2nd Lieut. Walter A. Clark, 0694220, of Syracuse, New York, took off from OwI Island to ferry a P-38J to Mokmer Drome and crashed into the water northeast of OwI.¹ On the same day 1st Lieut. Louis J. Graton, Jr., 0737074, of Lompoc, California, was hospitalized with a back injury after crashing near our strip where he attempted to land with his left engine feathered and the right engine cut out.

1. For details see pp 1, 8th Squadron Report, September 1944.

WRECK INVESTIGATION REPORT (WIR) 1000

27 November, 1964

Anyone standing at a safe distance and watching the 1000 Light Group during the month of September would witness a whirlwind of activity. A look through the dust at the airship would reveal the 75 and 80. Spent pilots climbing farwell to their faith in 1-10's and undergoing a rigorous training program to rejoin themselves with the twin engine 1-32. Although many pilots were reluctant to make the change because of a long nostalgic feeling for the 1-10's, they realized the advantages of the increased range and speed with the 1-32. Yet no man would ever dream to make any slightly distant trip without about a 1-10 to 1-32 plane, else the 1-10's are kind of a dead end by an extremely fast 1-10 pilot whose respect for that plane will never dwindle. As an all round rugged 1-10 and also handy the 1-10 will never be forgotten by the old hands who flew from Hawaii to Alaska, Alaska and Australia.

This intensive training program was not without some setbacks. The 8th Squadron had the troubles and tragedies. On September 1st, 1st Lt. Walter A. Clark, 1000000, of 1000000, New York, took off from 1st Island to carry a 1-32 to 1000000 and crashed into the water northeast of 1000000. On the same day 1st Lt. Walter A. Clark, 1000000, of 1000000, of 1000000, California, was contacted with a back injury after crashing near our ship where he attempted to land with his left engine feathered and the right engine cut out.

For details see pp 1, 8th Squadron Report, September 1964.

S E C R E T

Pp 2, Historical Record, Hq 49th Ftr Gp, September 1944, cont'd:

On September 25th, 2nd Lieut. Richard H. Remer, 0754197, of Urbana, Texas, took off on a transition flight and was never seen or heard of again.¹

Meanwhile the 7th Squadron had its rough going. On the 22nd, while on a training flight, 2nd Lieut. Roland Humphrey of Mt. Clemens, Michigan, a new pilot, crashed into the water off Biak and was killed.²

On the 27th the 7th Squadron furnished one of the most confusing and hopelessly tangled crash mysteries in our history when 2nd Lieut. Jay G. Rogers, 0754670, of Longmont, California, took off from Mokmer strip and vanished, leaving behind many clues and false hopes for his rescue.³

Double Trouble for Mechanics

The pilots were not alone in their efforts to get acquainted with the twin engined Lightning. The "Going Home" list left many vacancies among the line personnel at a time when all hands were needed for engine changes and work on twin engined planes in place of the P-40's. Replacements were looked for eagerly to fill these gaps. Tech supply was having difficulties in acquiring much needed equipment for the old P-38J's given to the 7th and 8th Squadrons.

Being tied up with their training program these two squadrons devoted only a few hours to combat flying. Early in the month Jap remnants on Biak were delivered 500 pound bombs. On September 1st Babo Strip was blasted and rendered unserviceable and on the 10th Samate Strip No. 1 received visits from the 7th and 8th Squadrons.

9th Squadron Hits the Philippines

The 9th Squadron started out September with a visit to the Philippines, pleased for the honor and opportunity to be among the first fighters to hit these islands. The squadron went to Middleburg, Dutch New Guinea and on 1

1. See pp 3, 8th Sqdn History, Sept 44.

2. See pp 5, 7th Sqdn History, Sept 44.

3. See pp 5, 7th Sqdn History, Sept 44.

1. The first of these was the fact that the VFW was not a political organization.

On October 23rd, 1941, the VFW was organized in the city of Dallas, Texas. It was organized by a group of men who were interested in the welfare of the veterans of the World War.

At the time of its organization, the VFW was a small organization. It had only a few members and was not very active. However, it grew rapidly and by 1945 it had over 100 members.

On the 27th of the month of September, 1945, the VFW was organized in the city of Dallas, Texas. It was organized by a group of men who were interested in the welfare of the veterans of the World War.

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Being tied up with their training program, the two speakers devoted only a few hours to the VFW. They were not able to do much more than to give a few words of encouragement to the members of the VFW. They were not able to do much more than to give a few words of encouragement to the members of the VFW.

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Pp 3, Historical Record, Hq 49th Ftr Gp, September 1944, cont'd:

September started for Davao, Mindanao Island, but hit a bad weather front and returned disappointed. The next day however, they succeeded in reaching the target. The resistance was surprisingly light. No enemy fighters arose and the ground fire was very slight and inaccurate. This 690 mile flight to the target was the longest haul yet attempted by our P-38's.

The 9th Squadron had their bad luck on September 3rd when 1st Lieut. John C. McLean, 04743356, of Chicago, Illinois, spun in just offshore at Biak while returning from a bombing mission against Amahai Airdrome.

The Halmaheras were visited by the 9th Squadron planes as punches were thrown at Galela and Djailela.

On the 6th the only kill of the month was chalked up when four 9th Squadron planes were escorting a PBY rescue plane in the Northern Celebes. A lone Zeke dropped two phosphorous bombs in an attempt to hit the formation and was quickly latched by 1st Lieut. Huard H. Norton, 0751418, of Norman, Oklahoma, and 1st Lieut. William J. Baxter, 0804314, of Macon, Georgia¹.

2nd Lieut. Henry J. Frank, 0763148, of San Francisco, California, bailed out over enemy controlled territory on September 11th during a strafing attack on the Boela oil fields. Both engines caught fire either from ground fire or due to mechanical trouble. Bad weather prevented searching for Lieut. Frank until the 15th when the Boela area was searched with nil sightings.

On the 17th of the month nearly all of the 9th Squadron pilots went to Nadzab to ferry back the new P-38L's.

1. PP 2, 9th Sqdn History, Sept 44.

Pp 4, Historical Record, Hq 49th Ftr Gp, September 1944, cont'd:

Group Headquarters gave a sendoff for a few homeward bound old timers.¹ Captain Kenneth J. Smith, 0435105, of Clarkrange, Tennessee, turned his communications department over to Captain Jacob Esser who had been his assistant and headed home. Smitty will be missed by all Headquarters men who will long remember the Captain's ability to hear Jap planes miles away. He had earned the nickname "Radar Ears" because of this ability.

1st Lieut. Wendell W. Wilbur, 02034649, of Alvin, Illinois, Engineering Officer, turned his department over to Captain Walter E. Huckabee, 0424268, of Thoniaton, Georgia, and joined Captain Smith homeward bound. Lieut. Wilbur came overseas as an enlisted man and then completed OCS in Australia.

The five happy enlisted men to leave were S/Sgt. Woodrow T. Southards, 34117738, Highpoint, North Carolina, S/Sgt. Frank K. Stetson, 14056070, Fort Pierce, Florida, Sgt. Walter S. Burnette, 34095584, Langley, South Carolina, Cpl. John F. Williams, 15068451, Louisville, Kentucky, and Cpl. William C. Crockett, 34057385, Miami, Florida.

Captain John C. Davis, 0469580, of Independence, Missouri, came to Headquarters from the 8th Squadron to take up the duties of Assistant Operations Officer on the 19th.

Red Alert

Air raids were scarce during the month with only two "active" nights. On September 1st a few bombs were dropped in the vicinity of Soredo Strip with no damage reported. On the 9th, 8 to 10 bombers hit Owi Island and Biak. No damage was done our installations on Biak but Owi suffered some damage. The ack-ack and searchlights got together and put on a beautiful but disappointing show. The P-61's fared better when a Jap was shot down north of Japen Island.

1. Par 2, SO 256, Hq, V Fighter Command, 12 Sept 44.

Pp 5, Historical Record, Hq 49th Ftr Gp, September 1944, cont'd:

Another Nip went down that night but after comparing Night Fighter reports it was found no one claimed him and it is assumed that a trigger happy Jap shot his pal down in the confusion.

Preparing to Move

Towards the latter part of the month the wheels of movement began to grind as packing and crating began. The chapel, officers' club and volleyball courts were the first to be removed. Spanish classes conducted by Pfc Luis E. Lopez, 32417233, of New York City, were eagerly attended as the Philippines rumor grew.

The end of the month found many men in the Group wearing additional stripes. The list was long and an entire Special Order was devoted to this purpose.¹

End of Chapter 11

- 30 -

1. SO 85, Hq, 49th Ftr Gp, 19 September 1944.

[REDACTED]

HISTORY OF THE 49TH FIGHTER GROUP

Chapter 11

(1-30 September 1944)

INDEX

a. Original Unit	Not applicable
b. Changes in Organization	Incl # 1
c. Strength	Incl # 1
d. Stations	BIAK
e. Number of Sorties	Incl # 1
f. Bombs dropped and ammunition fired	Incl # 1
g. Aerial attacks on our ground installations.	Incl # 1
h. Ground battles engaged in by unit	Nil.
i. Losses in action	Nil.
j. Former and present members who have distinguished themselves in action	Nil.
k. Photographs of personnel, important scenes, or events	Nil.
l. Other relevant statistical data	Incl # 1

S E C R E T

HISTORY OF THE 49TH FIGHTER GROUP

Chapter 11

(1-30 September 1944)

LIST OF INCLOSURES

1. Statistical data.

OFFICE OF THE ATTORNEY GENERAL

WASHINGTON, D.C.

(Attorney General's Office)

MEMORANDUM FOR THE ATTORNEY GENERAL

RE: [Illegible]

[Illegible stamp]

HEADQUARTERS 49TH FIGHTER GROUP
ARMY AIR FORCES
APO 920

27 November 1944.

STATISTICAL DATA (September 1944)
Group Headquarters, 7th, 8th and 9th Fighter Squadrons.

A. Strength.

1. Personnel.

	<u>Flying</u>	<u>Ground</u>
a. At beginning of period	121	813
b. Net increase	28	53
c. Net decrease	24	135
d. At end of period	125	731

2. Aircraft.

	<u>P-38's</u>	<u>P-40's</u>
a. At beginning of period	45	53
b. Net increase	25	0
c. Net decrease	0	53
d. At end of period	70	0

B. Number of Sorties.

<u>7th Squadron</u>		<u>8th Squadron</u>	
1. Reconnaissance	0	1. Search	52
2. Bombing		2. Bombing	
a. Number of missions	76	a. Number of missions	78
b. Ton miles flown	2,862	b. Ton miles flown	6,973.5
3. Bomber cover	0	3. Scramble	15
4. Patrol	0	4. Radar	2
5. Others	6	5. Courier	2
		6. Ferry	1
		7. Gunnery	1
		8. Transition	1

<u>9th Squadron</u>	
1. Reconnaissance	0
2. Bombing missions	89
3. Bomber cover	26
4. Interception	4
5. Fighter Sweep	4
6. Patrols	5
7. Search	6

C. Bombs dropped and ammunition fired.

1. 7th Squadron.

- 1 -

Incl #1.

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11 November 1964

GROUP HEADQUARTERS, 1ST AIRBORNE DIVISION, 100TH AIRBORNE AIRBORNE DIVISION

A. Summary

1. Personnel

1. At beginning of period	131	131
2. Not returned	28	28
3. Not reported	24	24
4. At end of period	132	132

2. Equipment

1. At beginning of period	48	48
2. Not returned	25	25
3. Not reported	0	0
4. At end of period	40	40

B. Number of Services

1. Personnel

1. Personnel	1	1
2. Equipment	2	2
3. Number of Services	4	4
4. Number of Services	1	1
5. Number of Services	1	1
6. Number of Services	1	1
7. Number of Services	1	1
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1. Personnel
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0. Number of Services

1. Personnel

SECRET

Pp 2, Gp Stat Data, Sept 44, cont'd:

a. Bombs.

- (1) 43.5 tons general purpose and instantaneous frags.
- (2) Results: Excellent, largely concentrated on Samate strip and coastal targets on Biak.

b. Ammunition expended.

- 91) 63,820 rds X .50 cal.
- (2) Results: Strafing largely confined to coastal villages on Biak occupied by Japanese. Average coverage about 80 per cent.

2. 8th Squadron.

a. Bombs.

- (1) 26.75 tons 500 lb demos; 3.68 tons 120 lb frag bombs.
- (2) Results: 1 jetty, 5 huts and 2 shacks destroyed, and Babo and Samate Dromes left unserviceable.

b. Ammunition expended.

- (1) Combat: None.
- (2) Strafing: 18,900 rds X .50 cal, results unobserved.

3. 9th Squadron.

a. Bombs.

- (1) 73 X 1000 lb bombs dropped.
- (2) Results:
 - 5 Sept: Dive bombed Galela area; 2 large fires started.
 - 7 Sept: Dive bombed Djailolo airdrome in Halmaheras; all bombs exploded on strip.
 - 10 Sept: Dive bomb Amahai strip; started 1 large fire on NE end of strip, rendered unserviceable.
 - 11 Sept: Dive bombed Boela oilfields; 9 bombs fell in storage tanks areas.
 - 30 Sept: Dive bombed Amahai strip; bombs lit on and around runway.

b. Ammunition expended.

- (1) 8,510 rds X .50 cal and 1298 rds 20mm.
- (2) Results:
 - 6 Sept: 1 Zeke destroyed approx 20 miles east of Lamheh Island.
 - 7 Sept: 12 P-38's strafed Sanoe starting many fires. Several large warehouses set on fire.

D. Aerial attacks by enemy on our ground installations.

9 Sept: 8-10 enemy bombers raided Owi Island and Biak area. No bombs fell in our area.

E. Ground battles engaged in by unit: None.

Robert J. Boniece
 ROBERT J. BONIECE,
 1st Lieut., Air Corps,
 Historical Officer.

[REDACTED]

Robert J. Jones

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DOD DIR 5200.9

